



(Don't Write
anything in this Area)

(a) Discuss Victor Turner's concept of liminality and communitas in the context of religious rituals. (20 marks)

Victor Turner belonged to the Symbolic School of Anthropology. He gave concept of liminality and communitas based on his study of Ndembu's in his book "Schism and continuity in African Society".

Briefs on Turner's Symbolic approach

→ Turner was inspired from Durkheim's idea of social fact.

→ He believed that culture is a set of symbols whose meaning should be understood in its own cultural context.

→ For Turner, symbols are operators in the social process, which tie the individual to the norms of society.

- (b) aid in change of status.
- (c) produce social transformation
- (d) instigate social action
- (e) help in resolving conflict →
idea of social drama

Turner's idea of liminality and communitas

- Turner studied the puberty ritual around the Medji tree symbol in Ademba.
- he borrowed the idea of rites of passage, i.e. the stage of transition ~~from~~ during a ritual from Van-Gennep.
- He divided the rituals into pre-liminal, liminal and post-liminal stages.
- The liminal stage or liminality represents the change in status of an individual during the ritual.

→ As per Turner, liminality is stage in limbo or a structureless stage.

→ All the past structures and differences are broken down during this phase and the entire society going through liminal stage experiences communitas, i.e. an intense community spirit and feeling of social solidarity.

→ This feeling of communitas helps in recreating the social life and ensure that social stability and social structure is maintained.

→ He talks of Social drama which starts with breach, crisis, redressal and then schism or continuity.

→ It is during the redressal mechanism that the society undergoes liminality leading to communitas preventing the society from disintegrating.

→ In his study of Adembris, Turner showed that the [Madyi tree] was dominant symbol around which the entire society experience communitas during puberty ritual thus preventing schism.

Thus Victor Turner via use of liminality and communitas successfully showed the role played by symbols in ensuring social stability and recreating social life.